



OFFICIAL

NMHS POLICY

Duress Alarm

Scope (Audience)	All workers at NMHS
Scope (Area)	All areas of NMHS
Summary	This policy outlines the minimum requirements relating to the management of duress alarms across NMHS, including roles and responsibilities.
Risk Rating	Medium
Policy Set	Health Safety and Wellbeing
Policy Sponsor	Executive Director People and Culture
Policy Contact	Director Health Safety and Wellbeing
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COMPLIANCE WITH THIS DOCUMENT IS MANDATORY

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1. Aim

This policy outlines the minimum requirements relating to the management of duress alarms across North Metropolitan Health Service (NMHS), including roles and responsibilities.

2. Background

NMHS as a Person Conducting Business or Undertaking (PCBU), aims to meet its Work Health and Safety (WHS) responsibilities to protect workers from harm by providing serviced and fully operational duress alarms with appropriate coverage and oversight where they have been assessed as practicable.

The duress response system is provided to people in areas risk assessed as requiring fixed-point and/or personal duress alarms (PDA) to increase safety and security measures.

The provision for a PCBU to develop and maintain safe systems of work is prescribed in the [Work Health and Safety Act 2020 \(WA\)](#). Failure to provide a safe system of work may result in harm to workers, patients and other people; negatively impact organisational reputation and culture, legislative non-compliance, and increased insurance claims costs.

Penalties are prescribed for Industrial Manslaughter within the [Work Health and Safety Act 2020 \(WA\)](#) as well as penalties for the body corporate and individual where death or serious harm occurs to an individual.

3. Policy Requirements

All workers have a general duty of care to maintain their own safety and health at work, and ensure the safety of colleagues, patients and other persons (s. 28 [Work Health and Safety Act 2020 \(WA\)](#)). This includes complying with all safety and health instructions and making use of safety systems and procedures provided by NMHS.

Workers must never hesitate to activate a fixed-point duress or PDA if they or others are at risk of imminent harm. This may be followed up with a “55 Code Black” call to raise a Code Black response if and where applicable.

In instances where workers are within the community and require emergency response, they should activate their PDA and a Triple Zero “000” must be called.

Facilities Management is responsible for the initial procurement, supply, maintenance and testing schedules at each NMHS site for all internal use PDAs.

Where Facilities Management does not have oversight of the areas who provide services then the manager of the area is responsible for the procurement, supply, maintenance and testing schedules for PDAs.

3.1 Issuing and Recording

Areas with personal duress alarms in use will have protocols in place to manage the issuing and recording of duress alarms and these will be documented in a register.

Duress alarms will be issued to all persons working in environments where they may be required, and official visitors visiting in an area where a duress alarm may be needed.

Additional duress alarms will be maintained onsite to ensure that any additional workers have access to duress alarms.

Managers/supervisors of the department issuing the duress alarms will ensure that an accurate record is maintained. The record is to be checked regularly to ensure that all duress alarms are accounted for. In instances where a duress alarm is missing, the Manager/Supervisor must follow up with the last recorded worker who was allocated the duress alarm.

Workers must **not** swap or share PDAs once issued unless the department has a comprehensive way of tracking who the duress alarm has been issued to.

3.2 Testing

The frequency of duress alarm testing will be determined upon the installation of the system. This is to be communicated to all relevant site-based managers/supervisors. As a minimum a fixed-point duress alarm will be tested annually/or as per local site processes to ensure compliance.

As the testing requirements may be different for each type of duress alarm, managers/supervisors must liaise with Security Department/Facilities Management Department regarding testing procedures.

Some duress alarm systems will require more regular testing than prescribed in this policy, including daily testing for some systems.

A register logging the testing of duress alarms will contain, as a minimum, the date and time that each alarm is tested and the names/signatures of the worker undertaking the tests.

Workers at NMHS sites/services (excluding Home and Community Services) issued with a PDA are responsible for testing and/or checking to ensure that it is operational once per shift and an adequate record of this action is maintained by the relevant workplace manager/supervisor.

PDAs issued for Home and Community Services use must be checked daily to determine functionality and an adequate record of this action is maintained by the relevant workplace managers/supervisors.

3.3 Fault Reporting

Faults will be reported immediately to site/service Facilities Management Department and where applicable reported direct to the supplier for rectification/remediation or replacement.

NMHS Health Safety & Wellbeing Department will be contacted to discuss strategies to maintain a safe working environment while the duress system is out of order.

Any worker must report a fault with the duress alarm system verbally immediately to the Manager/Supervisor.

Managers/supervisors are responsible for ensuring that notification of faults to Facilities Management and NMHS Health Safety & Wellbeing occurs as soon as possible, and any strategy to maintain a safe environment is communicated to all workers in the area.

3.4 Activation

NMHS workers must call for assistance and activate the duress or PDA, where available, when worker experiences or witnesses any of the following in the workplace:

- Violent behaviour

- Aggression or threats towards workers/patients/visitors
- Feeling unsafe

Workers must ensure their own safety. When it is safe to do so, workers will then summon assistance by:

- Calling '55' and declaring a Code Black (where appropriate) and/or
- Activating a Duress Alarm (where available) and/or
- Calling site Security directly (where available).

Duress alarms may either be fixed hard wired or personal mobile alarms.

Response will be provided by workers within the duress pager group, where implemented. Only workers with appropriate skill in dealing with violence and aggression will be allocated to the duress pager group.

Sites/services must develop and maintain procedures detailing their response to the activation of a duress alarm.

3.5 Education/Training

Managers/supervisors are responsible for ensuring all relevant workers who work in an area where duress alarms are located/provided receive training on their use.

Workers will undertake duress alarm exercise to ensure compliance and to maintain worker awareness and security. Duress alarm exercise will at minimum be practised annually/or as per local site processes to ensure compliance.

Where monitoring is provided by an external contractor, managers/supervisors are to develop their duress alarm exercises in collaboration with the relevant contractor.

All NMHS workers are required to attend mandatory training for the management of workplace violence and aggression as per local site processes.

4. Roles and Responsibilities

Roles	Responsibilities
NMHS Chief Executive	Is responsible for: • providing leadership on safety and is ultimately accountable for the safety and security of all NMHS workers, patients, visitors and other persons.
NMHS Executive Directors	Are responsible for: • Management of a safe environment within their areas of responsibility • Ensuring compliance with this policy within their areas of responsibility.
Facilities Management NMHS	Are responsible for: • Ensuring all onsite fixed-point duress alarms are tested at minimum annually to ensure they are operational. • Ensuring all onsite PDAs have been tested prior to becoming operational.



	- Ensuring all Duress Alarms that are not operational are reported via EMPAC immediately and to the manager of the area. - Ensuring all Duress Alarm test report sheets are completed and forwarded to the Emergency Management Unit.
Managers /Supervisors at NMHS sites/services (excluding Home and Community Services)	Dependent upon the site/service local procedure, the responsibilities of managers/supervisors include the following at a minimum: - Ensuring workers are provided with orientation to Duress Alarm locations and Code Black procedures. - Ensuring workers who are at high risk of being exposed to aggressive or threatening behaviours are provided with a PDA or other means of emergency communication. - Ensuring workers who are issued PDAs receive adequate orientation and instructions on using and testing the alarm or emergency communication. - Ensuring all onsite PDAs are tested and/or checked by the worker on each shift to ensure they are operational. - Ensuring that incidents are reported and investigated in accordance with the NMHS Hazard/Incident Reporting and Investigation Policy. - Reporting issues with the duress alarm system to Facilities Management in a timely manner; and followed by an EMPAC work request flagged as urgent. - Ensuring that, where required by risk assessment or procedure, workers always carry an operational PDA.
Managers /Supervisors at Home and Community Services	Managers/supervisors who are responsible for the oversight of workers engaging with consumers in either the home or community visiting must ensure: - There is a procedure for instructing workers on planning and risk assessing each home or community visit prior to entering the community. - There is a procedure for advising manager of risk where workers feel a home or community visit is not safe. - Mandatory carrying of PDAs by workers. - The department has an adequate supply of duress alarms for workers, and procedures to follow if duress alarms are not available. - There is an emergency response plan developed should a PDA be activated. - Workers are empowered by NMHS to end a visit at any point if they believe they are at risk of aggression and/or violence. - Workers understand they must dial “000” when in the community to seek police assistance.
All workers of NMHS	Are responsible for: - Having knowledge of the policy documents relevant to their roles and how to access these documents. - Complying with mandatory requirements outlined in these documents. - Assisting with policy development/reviews wherever required.

- Reporting to their immediate line manager any potential non-compliance or implementation issues.

5. Monitoring and Evaluation

Compliance with this policy is mandatory. There are legislative obligations relating to this policy where a statutory penalty may apply for non-compliance.

This policy will be evaluated as required to determine its currency, relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, and sustainability. At a minimum, it will be reviewed **every three years** using a risk management approach in accordance with the [NMHS Policy Governance Framework](#).

6. Definition

Terms	Definitions
Code Black	A Code Black is a call for assistance, when any individual feels themselves or others are at risk from an act of aggression, or there is a perceived risk to property. There are five different types of Code Black that can be activated 'Personal Threat', 'Self Harm', 'Armed-Hold-up', 'Alpha' or 'Bravo'.
Duress Alarm	A device that, when activated, indicates a person is under threat and requires immediate assistance. • Fixed Point Duress Alarm: Fixed-point duress alarm buttons are strategically located throughout a facility often fixed under desks or to walls, which are hard-wired to a pager alert system. • Personal Duress Alarm (PDA): A wireless device, worn or carried by a person, for mobile activation of a duress alarm inside the workplace and/or while on home/community visits.
Emergency Response Team (ERT)	Allocated workers whose role is the response to emergency codes within the hospital.
Pager Alert System	An enterprise communication system, monitored by the relevant Emergency Response Team (ERT) workers, which provides real time alerts to facilitate immediate and appropriate response to duress alarms.
Triple Zero "000"	Emergency Telephone Number for workers in the community, or sites where there is no Code Black response available or "55".
Worker	According to the Work Health and Safety Act 2020, a person is a worker if the person carries out work in any capacity for NMHS, including work as – a) an employee; or b) a contractor or subcontractor; or c) an employee of a contractor or subcontractor; or d) an employee of a labour hire company who has been assigned to work in NMHS; or e) an outworker; or f) an apprentice or trainee; or



	g) a student gaining work experience; or h) a volunteer; or i) a person of a prescribed class.
Workplace	Consistent with the WA Health Work Health and Safety Management Policy (MP 0180/23) , the term refers to: Any place where a worker goes or is likely to be while work is carried out for the department. This may include offices, home based work sites, factories, shops, construction sites, vehicles, ships, aircraft or other mobile structures on land or water.

7. Related Documents

Legislation	• Work Health and Safety Act 2020 (WA) • Work Health and Safety (General) Regulations 2022 (WA)
NMHS Policy documents	• NMHS Hazard/Incident Reporting and Investigation Policy • NMHS Home and Community Visits Policy (coming soon) • NMHS Policy Governance Framework • NMHS Working Alone Policy

8. Resources

[Commission for Occupational Safety & Health - Code of Practice: Violence, Aggression and Bullying at Work \(2010\)](#)

9. Document Control

Version	Policy author	Summary of changes	TRIM Reference	Approval date
1.0	J. Harkin	Original version	D/25/229050	29/08/2025 (Published 03/09/2025)

This document can be made available in alternative formats on request for a person with a disability.

Within the Department of Health WA, the term Aboriginal is used in preference to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander, in recognition that Aboriginal people are the original inhabitants of Western Australia. No disrespect is intended to our Torres Strait Islander colleagues and community.

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